

Back to The Future

We live at the culmination of everything humanity has learned about teaching, and it would be difficult to argue that any earlier system was more comprehensive or more advanced than ours. Thus, if I am being honest, I would rather stay in the present era of education. However, if I were to choose one period, specifically in the past, I would set the dial to the Middle Ages. I would go back not for its cathedrals or its castles, but for two of its educational systems that I believe understood something we are in danger of forgetting. These are the guild system of education and chivalric education. I love theories, philosophy, and abstraction, but I have come to value two things even more, and those are practicality and character.

The guild system draws me first because it never truly died. Its central contribution, the apprenticeship, is alive everywhere around us. We see it in internships, in probationary periods, in on-the-job training, and in every mentor and mentee arrangement in offices, hospitals, and businesses today. When a system invented nearly a thousand years ago still quietly runs beneath our modern institutions, that is not nostalgia. That is proof of design that works. What I admire most is how personal the transmission of knowledge was. A craft was not downloaded from a module or absorbed from a lecture hall of three hundred students. It was passed from one pair of hands to another, day after day, in the same workshop, over some seven years. That kind of closeness develops something no diploma can certify, which is a deep interpersonal bond and mutual respect between master and apprentice that endures long after the training ends. It was also an unforgiving education. The apprentice lived the craft, breathed it, and failed at it repeatedly under watchful eyes until failure became rare. Only then could an apprentice travel as a journeyman, and only a masterpiece could earn him the title of master, which is both symbolic and realistic. This intensity ensured genuine mastery and genuine readiness to pass the craft on to the next student. It is no accident that the craftsmanship of that era still stands today, in stone, in glass, and in gold.

I also see in the guild system a reflection of our own Filipino value of *Utang na Loob*. Apprentices held their masters in the highest regard for the rest of their lives, not because a rule demanded it, but because the debt of formation is a debt of the heart. It is the clearest example I know of the idea that respect is earned. I have experienced this myself. I have been

blessed with a few mentors who appeared at the right time and in the right place, when I badly needed guidance and did not even know how to ask for it. I carry their lessons the way a journeyman carries his tools, and I know I will spend my life paying that debt forward to students of my own. The system was not perfect, of course. Not every master was generous or nurturing, and some surely exploited the boys under their roofs. But the structure itself, personal and specialized, remains one of the finest training designs humanity has produced.

Yet mastery alone is not enough, and this is why I pair the guild with chivalric education. A man may be brilliant at his craft and still be poor in spirit. Chivalric education insisted that skill must be accompanied by good manners, loyalty, and compassion for the weak. I regard highly a person who knows exactly what he is doing, but I regard far more highly the person who is kind. This, I believe, is what is missing in many highly educated people today. We have produced experts in abundance but empathy in scarcity, minds that are sharp and hearts that are unpracticed. I come from humble beginnings, and I know how hard it is to rise through the ranks from having nothing to making ripples. Kindness and humility are not thinking less of yourself. It is remembering the ground you came from even when you are standing somewhere higher. The knight's oath to protect the defenseless is, to me, the oath every educated person should silently take.

In sum, these two medieval systems carry a lesson our current educational system still needs. The guild reminds us that education must produce competence through practice, patience, and personal mentorship, not merely through examinations. Chivalry reminds us that education must produce goodness, because knowledge without conscience is a sword without an oath. Perhaps our modern schools have inherited the guild's apprenticeship, but we are still catching up to chivalry's insistence that character is a subject, not a side effect. Thus, if I could go back in time, I would go to the Middle Ages, to the workshop and to the castle hall. I would go to learn a craft slowly, and I would return, I hope, with calloused hands and a softer heart, which is exactly what I believe modern education is for.

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